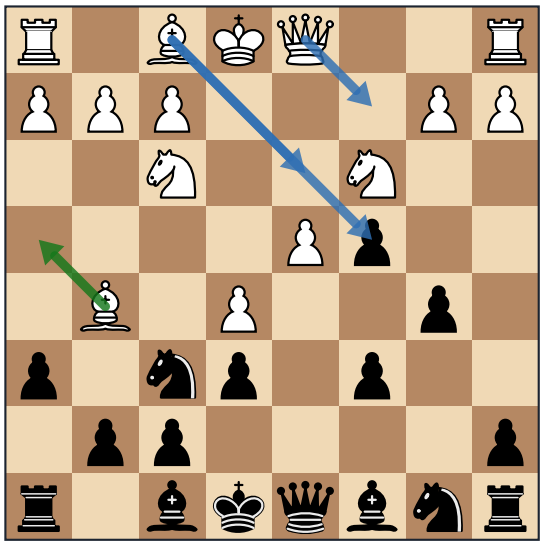
Semi-Slav Defense

ECO D30-D49 | 72 named lines | Queen's Gambit / Slav family

In one sentence: The classical 1.d4 opening: White fights for e4 and the center; Black chooses solid structures (QGD, Slav) or active ones (QGA).

Memory pattern: c4 vs d5: White takes the center, Black holds with e6 or c6 and breaks with ...c5.



Main line: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.Bg5 dxc4 6.e4 b5 7.e5 h6

Key ideas

1. Challenge d5 with c4: if Black takes (QGA), White regains the pawn and gets center.
2. QGD: Black holds d5 with ...e6; the light bishop is the problem piece.
3. Slav: ...c6 keeps the light bishop free for ...Bf5.
4. Exchange Carlsbad: White plays the minority attack b4-b5; Black counters with ...Ne4 and ...f5.
5. Black's freeing moves are ...c5 and ...e5; White's are e4 and Qc2/Bd3 kingside play.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.63** (slightly better for White, depth 19). Best: Bh4.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	c4/d4 against d5: Carlsbad (c6/e6), Slav chain (c6/d5), QGA (White regains c4), IQP or hanging pawns after exchanges. The minority attack (b4-b5) is White's key plan.
2. Where does my king go?	Both sides castle kingside; the king is rarely attacked early.
3. Best minor pieces?	White: Bg5/Bf4, Nc3/Nf3, Bd3, Rc1. Black: Nbd7, Bb7 or Bf5, Be7, Rc8.
4. Main middlegame plan?	White: minority attack, e4 break or Bd3-Qc2 kingside play. Black: ...c5/...e5 breaks and trading light bishops.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants e4 or a queenside attack; Black wants a pawn break (...c5/...e5) and active bishops.

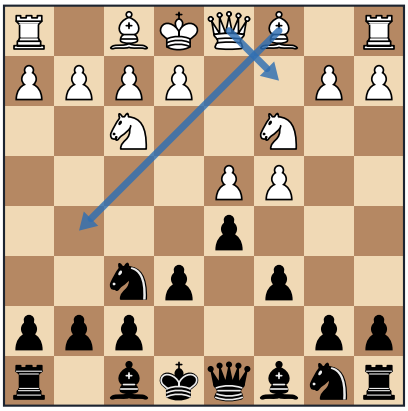
The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.Bg5 dxc4 6.e4 b5 7.e5 h6

Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... d5	Hold the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. c4	Attack d5. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... c6	Slav setup. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
3. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
3... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
4. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
4... e6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
5. Bg5	Pin Nf6. Develops the bishop to g5.
5... dxc4	Take the pawn. Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
6. e4	Central break. Occupies the center with a pawn.
6... b5	Gains space on the wing.
7. e5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
7... h6	Ask the bishop. Gains space on the wing.



After 1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6



After c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

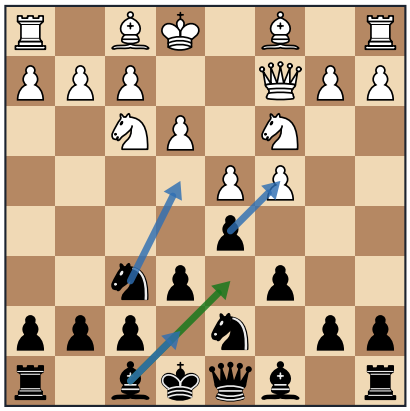


Position after the line

Meran Variation D47 | 19 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5`

Stockfish: **+0.23** (equal, depth 15). Best next move: Bd3.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Wade Variation, Sozin Variation, Lundin Variation, Old Variation

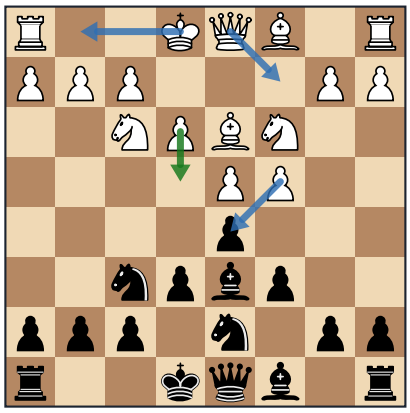


Position after the line

Stoltz Variation D45 | 8 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Qc2`

Stockfish: **+0.26** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: Bd6.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: Center Variation, Shabalov Attack

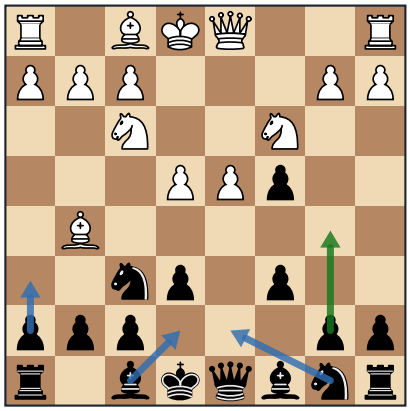


Position after the line

Chigorin Defense D46 | 8 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 Bd6`

Stockfish: **+0.60** (slightly better for White, depth 19). Best next move: e4.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)

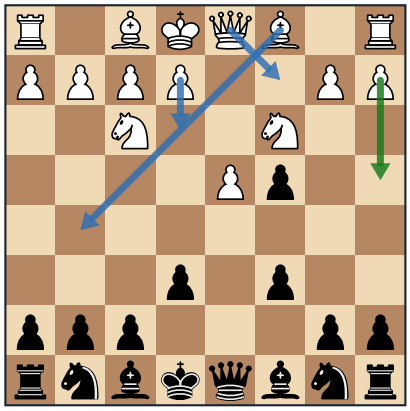


Position after the line

Botvinnik Variation D44 | 6 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.Bg5 dxc4 6.e4`

Stockfish: **+0.57** (slightly better for White, depth 20). Best next move: b5.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: Alatortsev System, Ekstrom Variation, Lilienthal Variation, Szabo Variation



Position after the line

Noteboom Variation D31 | 5 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.Nf3 dxc4`

Stockfish: **+0.31** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: a4.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Anti-Noteboom Variation, Abrahams Variation, Anti-Noteboom Gambit



Position after the line

Marshall Gambit D31 | 4 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.e4`

Stockfish: **+0.42** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: dxe4.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: Forgotten Variation, Main Line, Tolush Variation

Expert and coach view

Capablanca and Karpov played the Queen's Gambit Declined with great success.

What a coach would tell you

Know the three structures: Carlsbad (minority attack), IQP (attack vs blockade) and hanging pawns. Study the plans for each, then choose the QGD, Slav or QGA based on your style.

Why play it

The classical 1.d4 opening: White fights for e4 and the center; Black chooses solid structures (QGD, Slav) or active ones (QGA).

Typical mistakes

• Taking on c4 without a plan to hold the pawn (...b5) or return it.

• Playing Bg5 too early or Nf3 too early without considering ...Ne4 or ...c5.

• Ignoring the minority attack and allowing a permanently weak c6 pawn.

Typical tactics and traps

• Elephant Trap: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 Nbd7 5.cxd5 exd5 6.Nxd5? Nxd5! 7.Bxd8 Bb4+ and Black wins.

• Back-rank tactics when queens trade and the rooks are unconnected.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

QGD endings are usually balanced; Black's solid structure makes winning chances hard for White.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Semi-Slav Defense (all lines)** D43
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6
  - **Accelerated Move Order** D31
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6
  - **Marshall Gambit** D31
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.e4
    - **Forgotten Variation** D31
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.e4 -> 4...dxe4 5.Nxe4 Bb4 6.Nc3
    - **Main Line** D31
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.e4 -> 4...dxe4 5.Nxe4 Bb4 6.Bd2
    - **Tolush Variation** D31
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.e4 -> 4...dxe4 5.Nxe4 Bb4 6.Bd2 Qxd4 7.Bxb4 Qxe4 8.Be2 c5 9.Bxc5 Qxg2
  - **Anti-Noteboom** D31
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.e3 f5
    - **Stonewall Variation** D31
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.e3 f5
      - **Portisch Gambit** D31
        1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.e3 f5 -> 5.g4
  - **Noteboom Variation** D31
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.Nf3 dxc4
    - **Anti-Noteboom Gambit** D31
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.Nf3 dxc4 -> 5.g3
    - **Anti-Noteboom Variation** D31
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.Nf3 dxc4 -> 5.Bg5
      - **Belyavsky Line** D31
        1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.Nf3 dxc4 5.Bg5 -> 5...f6
    - **Abrahams Variation** D31
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.Nf3 dxc4 -> 5.a4 Bb4 6.e3 Bxc3 7.bxc3 b5 8.axb5 cxb5
  - **Gunderam Gambit** D31
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.e4 dxe4 5.f3
  - **Main Line** D45
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3
  - **Quiet Variation** D30
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nbd2
  - **Accelerated Meran Variation** D45
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 a6
  - **Normal Variation** D45
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7
  - **Anti-Moscow Gambit** D43
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 -> 5.Bg5 h6 6.Bh4
  - **Botvinnik Variation** D44
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 -> 5.Bg5 dxc4 6.e4
    - **Alatortsev System** D44
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 d5 4.Nc3 c6 5.Bg5 dxc4 6.e4 b5 7.e5 h6 8.Bh4 g5 9.Nxg5 Nd5
    - **Ekstrom Variation** D44
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.Bg5 dxc4 6.e4 -> 6...b5 7.e5 h6 8.Bh4 g5 9.exf6 gxh4 10.Ne5
    - **Lilienthal Variation** D44
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.Bg5 dxc4 6.e4 -> 6...b5 7.e5 h6 8.Bh4 g5 9.Nxg5 hxg5 10.Bxg5 Nbd7 11.g3
    - **Szabo Variation** D44
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 d5 4.Nc3 c6 5.Bg5 dxc4 6.e4 b5 7.e5 h6 8.Bh4 g5 9.Nxg5 hxg5 10.Bxg5 Nbd7 11.Qf3
  - **Rubinstein System** D45
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.Nf3 Nf6 5.e3 Nbd7 6.Ne5
  - **Stoltz Variation** D45
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Qc2
    - **Center Variation** D45
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.e3 Nbd7 6.Qc2 Bd6 7.e4
      - **Mikhalchishin Line** D45
        1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.e3 Nbd7 6.Qc2 Bd6 7.e4 -> 7...dxe4 8.Nxe4 Nxe4 9.Qxe4 e5 10.dxe5

Shabalov Attack D45
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.e3 Nbd7 6.Qc2 Bd6 7.g4

Bogoljubow Variation D46
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 Be7

Chigorin Defense D46
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 Bd6

Moscow Variation D43
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 -> 5.Bg5 h6 6.Bxf6 Qxf6

Romih Variation D46
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 Bb4

Stonewall Defense D45
1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.c4 c6 4.Nc3 e6 5.e3 Ne4 6.Bd3 f5

Hastings Variation D43
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 -> 5.Bg5 h6 6.Bxf6 Qxf6 7.Qb3

Semi-Meran Variation D47
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4

Meran Variation D47
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5

Lundin Variation D47
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.e3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 8.Bd3 b4

Wade Variation D47
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 -> 8.Bd3 Bb7

Larsen Variation D47
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 8.Bd3 Bb7 -> 9.e4 b4 10.Na4 c5 11.e5 Nd5

Kaidanov Gambit D47
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 8.Bd3 Bb7 -> 9.e4 b4 10.Na4 c5 11.e5 N…

Pirc Variation D48
1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c6 4.e3 Nf6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 8.Bd3 a6 9.e4 b4

Old Variation D48
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 -> 8.Bd3 a6 9.e4 c5 10.e5

Reynolds' Variation D48
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.e3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 8.Bd3 a6 9.e4 c5 10.d5

Blumenfeld Variation D49
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 -> 8.Bd3 a6 9.e4 c5 10.e5 cxd4 11.Nxb5

Rabinovich Variation D49
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 -> 8.Bd3 a6 9.e4 c5 10.e5 cxd4 11.Nxb5 Ng4

Sozin Variation D49
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.e3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 8.Bd3 a6 9.e4 c5 10.e5 cxd4 11.Nxb5 Nxe5

Stahlberg Variation D49
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Nf3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 -> 8.Bd3 a6 9.e4 c5 10.e5 cxd4 11.Nxb5 Nxe5 …

Rellstab Attack D49
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Nf3 e6 5.e3 Nbd7 6.Bd3 dxc4 7.Bxc4 b5 8.Bd3 a6 9.e4 c5 10.e5 cxd4 11.Nxb5 Nxe5 1…

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

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1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.Bg5 dxc4
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Plan chain

White	c4 -> Nc3 -> Nf3 -> Bg5 -> e3
Black	d5 -> e6 -> Nf6 -> Be7 -> O-O

Three rules to remember

1. c4 vs d5: White takes the center, Black holds with e6 or c6 and breaks with ...c5.

2. White: minority attack, e4 break or Bd3-Qc2 kingside play. Black: ...c5/...e5 breaks and trading light bishops.

3. White wants e4 or a queenside attack; Black wants a pawn break (...c5/...e5) and active bishops.

Pawn structure in one line

c4/d4 against d5: Carlsbad (c6/e6), Slav chain (c6/d5), QGA (White regains c4), IQP or hanging pawns after exchanges. The minority attack (b4-b5) is White's key plan.